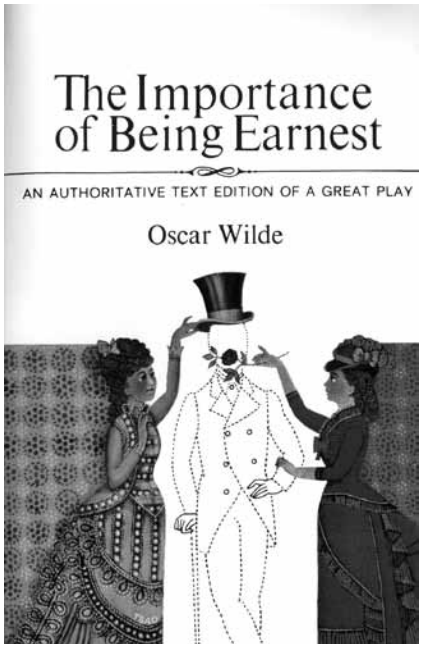
UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE

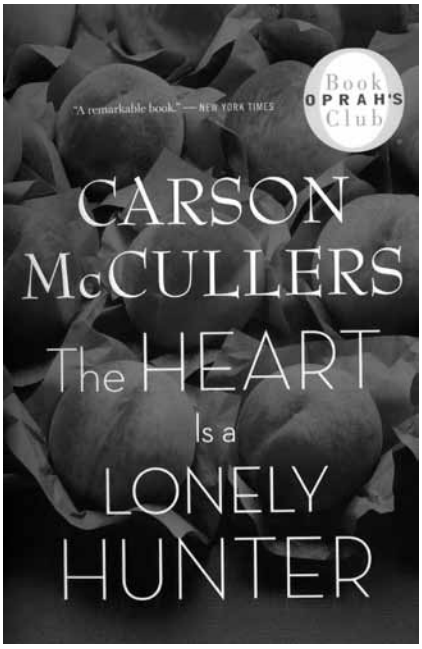
Making a World of Difference

Literary Criticism

District 1 • 2013







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University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest • District 1 • 2013

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. Considered a staple of human culture from the beginning, the unofficial exchange of information and opinions having to do with the private conduct of others is

   A) epistolary literature.
   B) folklore.
   C) gossip.
   D) pluralism.
   E) versification.

2. The French writer whom the Nobel committee considered an "author of new departures, poetic adventure and sensual ecstasy, explorer of a humanity beyond and below the reigning civilization" and who received the 2008 Nobel Prize for Literature is

   A) André Gide.
   B) Jean-Marie Gustave Le Clézio.
   C) François Mauriac.
   D) Jean-Paul Sartre.
   E) Claude Simon.

3. A proverb or saying made familiar by long use, such as "a stitch in time saves nine" is a(n)

   A) adage.
   B) anecdote.
   C) epigram.
   D) limerick.
   E) merism.

4. The figure of speech in which the literal sense of what is said fails detectably short of the magnitude of what is being talked about is called

   A) hyperbole.
   B) imagery.
   C) minimalism.
   D) understatement.
   E) verisimilitude.

5. An interlude in which the actors freeze in position and then resume action as before or hold their position until the curtain drops is a(n)

   A) meditation.
   B) montage.
   C) mosaic.
   D) tableau.
   E) uncial.

6. The term that means literally a manifestation or showing forth that designates an event in which the essential nature of something—a person, a situation, an object—is suddenly perceived is

   A) apostrophe.
   B) epiphany.
   C) locus classicus.
   D) nekuia.
   E) zeugma.

7. The early nineteenth-century New York literary group that includes Washington Irving, James Fenimore Cooper, and William Cullen Bryant, and which was based more on geography and chance rather than on close organization, is the

   A) Fireside Poets.
   B) Hartford Wits.
   C) Knickerbocker Group.
   D) Muckrakers.
   E) New York School.

8. The poetic foot consisting of an accented followed by an unaccented syllable is the

   A) choree.
   B) iamb.
   C) pyrrhic.
   D) spondee.
   E) trochee.

9. The recipient of the very first Pulitzer Prize for Poetry in 1918 for her collection entitled *Love Songs* is

   A) Rita Dove.
   B) Louise Glück.
   C) Sylvia Plath.
   D) Anne Sexton.
   E) Sara Teasdale.

10. **Not** considered as one of the chief elements or genres contributing to the development of Elizabethan drama is

    A) medieval drama.
    B) morality plays.
    C) Restoration drama.
    D) Roman comedies.
    E) Roman revenge tragedies.

11. The first major, self-conscious literary movement of African-American writers, which included Langston Hughes, Jean Toomer, Countee Cullen, Zora Neale Hurston, Arna Bontemps, and Claude McKay, is the
    A) Black Mountain School.
    B) Harlem Renaissance.
    C) New York Poets.
    D) Parnassians.
    E) Saturday Club.

12. The twentieth-century Jewish-American author of *Goodbye, Columbus*, *Portnoy's Complaint*, *The Dying Animal* and whose novel *American Pastoral* earned him the 1998 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction is
    A) Saul Bellow.
    B) John Cheever.
    C) Norman Mailer.
    D) Conrad Richter.
    E) Philip Roth.

13. The specific part of a plot in which develops the entanglement caused by the conflict of opposing forces is the
    A) climax.
    B) complication.
    C) dénouement.
    D) exposition.
    E) point of attack.

14. **Not** among the American writers who have died during our young century is
    A) William Golding.
    B) Arthur Miller.
    C) J. D. Salinger.
    D) John Updike.
    E) Kurt Vonnegut, Jr.

15. A word, phrase, or manner of expression, whether it is language, customs, dress, or any other characteristic, peculiar to a special region and not commonly used outside that region–therefore, not fashionable or sophisticated, is known as a
    A) barbarism.
    B) euphemism.
    C) Gongorism.
    D) provincialism.
    E) regionalism.

16. The portion of the English Renaissance during which there was a growth of realism in art and cynicism in thought and during which Shakespeare wrote his greatest tragedies and tragicomedies is the
    A) Augustan Age.
    B) Caroline Age.
    C) Edwardian Age.
    D) Georgian Age.
    E) Jacobean Age.

17. The period between the Jacksonian Era and the close of the Civil War in American literature, recognized as the country's first great creative period, is the
    A) Colonial Period.
    B) Federalist Period.
    C) Naturalistic and Symbolistic Period.
    D) Realistic Period.
    E) Romantic Period.

18. The early twentieth-century British author of *Heart of Darkness*, *Youth*, *Lord Jim*, *Nostromo*, *Typhoon*, and *Victory* is
    A) Kingsley Amis.
    B) Joseph Conrad.
    C) Ford Madox Ford.
    D) Rudyard Kipling.
    E) W. Somerset Maugham.

19. The recipient of the 1934 Pulitzer Prize for Drama for his play *Men in White* is
    A) Maxwell Anderson.
    B) Frank D. Gilroy.
    C) William Inge.
    D) Sidney Kingsley.
    E) Eugene O'Neill.

20. The early nineteenth-century group of aristocratic, liberal-minded New England poets devoted to providing intellectual and moral education, especially through the newly-emerging medium of the modern periodical, is called the
    A) Fireside Poets.
    B) Hartford Wits.
    C) Knickerbocker Group.
    D) Muckrakers.
    E) New York School.

21. The twentieth-century Pulitzer-winning author of *All the Pretty Horses*, *Blood Meridian*, *The Crossing*, *No Country for Old Men*, *Outer Dark*, and *The Road* is

A) William Faulkner.
B) Ernest Hemingway.
C) Cormac McCarthy.
D) Walker Percy.
E) John Steinbeck.

22. A narrative or tradition handed down from the past and characterized by having something of the historical truth and relatively little of the supernatural is called (a/an)

A) anecdote.
B) folklore.
C) legend.
D) myth.
E) parable.

23. The term applied to learned literature produced by writers dwelling in England between the mid-fifth century and the beginning of the sixteenth century, including chronicles, serious treatises on theology, philosophy, law, history, and science, as well as hymns, prayers, and religious plays, is

A) Anglo-Irish.
B) Anglo-Italian.
C) Anglo-Latin.
D) Anglo-Norman.
E) Anglo-Saxon.

24. A work or manner that blends a censorious attitude with humor and wit for improving human institutions or humanity in general is categorized as (an)

A) burlesque.
B) exordium.
C) irony.
D) meliorism.
E) satire.

25. The instructiveness in a literary work, one purpose of which is to give guidance in moral, ethical, or religious matters, is known as

A) aestheticism.
B) catechism.
C) determinism.
D) didacticism.
E) humanism.

26. **Not** among the several literary genres that have been informed by the poetic, i.e. imaginative or romantic, treatment of shepherds and rustic life, which is known as the pastoral mode, are

A) dialogue poems.
B) dramatic tragedies.
C) elegies.
D) narrative romances.
E) romantic comedies.

27. The identity of terminal sound between primarily accented syllables, usually occupying corresponding positions in two or more lines of verse, is known as

A) breve.
B) diction.
C) pitch.
D) macron.
E) rhyme.

28. Literature reflecting both romantically and realistically the great changes, especially the changes that engendered the doubts and the hopes raised by the new science, that were going on in life and thought during the better part of nineteenth-century Britain is called

A) Edwardian literature.
B) Georgian literature.
C) Jacobean literature.
D) Restoration literature.
E) Victorian literature.

29. The state of having more than one meaning, with resultant uncertainty to the intended significance of the statement is a(n)

A) ambiguity.
B) false friend.
C) paradox.
D) redundancy.
E) tautology.

30. The Dominican-American author of *The Brief Wondrous Life of Oscar Wao*, which earned him the 2008 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction, is

A) Junot Diaz.
B) Oscar Hijuelos.
C) Richard Russo.
D) Michael Shaara.
E) Peter Taylor.

Part 2: The UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

Items 31-36 are associated with Oscar Wilde's *The Importance of Being Earnest*.
Items 37-42 are associated with Carson McCullers's *The Heart Is a Lonely Hunter*.
Items 43-50 are associated with Samuel Taylor Coleridge's poetry (selected).

31. In Wilde's *Importance of Being Earnest*, Algy's remark, "Really, if the lower orders don't set us a good example, what on earth is the use of them? They seem, as a class, to have absolutely no sense of moral responsibility," follows a personal criticism of
    A) Chasuble.
    B) Earnest.
    C) Lane.
    D) Jack.
    E) Merriman.

32. Lady Bracknell's bluntly delivered observation, "To lose one parent [. . .] may be regarded as a misfortune; to lose both looks like carelessness," is directed at
    A) Gwendolen Fairfax.
    B) Cecily Cardew.
    C) Canon Chasuble.
    D) Algernon Moncrieff.
    E) John Worthing.

33. Resonating as a deep reproof of the aristocratic class, "My duty as gentleman has never interfered with my pleasures in the smallest degree" as an unapologetic confession, is delivered by
    A) Algernon.
    B) Bunbury.
    C) Chasuble.
    D) Jack.
    E) John.

34. Chasuble's being troubled by Jack's change of the afternoon's plans as "savour[ing] of the heretical views of the Anabaptists" is offset by the Canon's
    A) discovery of a plate of cucumber sandwiches.
    B) expectation that Miss Prism is waiting for him.
    C) finding Miss Prism's three-volume novel.
    D) meeting Mr. Bunbury for the first time.
    E) remembering that the baptismal font is broken.

35. Mr. Worthing's ward is
    A) Augusta Bracknell.
    B) Cecily Cardew.
    C) Gwendolen Fairfax.
    D) Algernon Moncrieff.
    E) Laetitia Prism.

36. Gwendolen, in responding to Jack's pretense of having a brother in order to "have an opportunity of coming up to town to see [her] as often as possible," declares that she has "the gravest doubts" regarding his explanation, but she intends to
    A) "act on them."
    B) "build on them."
    C) "crush them."
    D) "share them."
    E) "renew them."

37. In McCullers's *The Heart Is a Lonely Hunter*, Biff's reflection, "Sometimes he talked like a lunthead and sometimes like a professor," describes
    A) Spiros Antonapoulos.
    B) Jake Blount.
    C) Benedict Copeland.
    D) Mick Kelly.
    E) John Singer.

38. Portia's response to Mick's "Do you notice anything different?" which is to suggest applying some grease, "the best thing for bad sunburn," and rub it on her face, constitutes
    A) ambiguity.
    B) catharsis.
    C) dramatic irony.
    D) hyperbole.
    E) understatement.

39. Asking Mick to bring him "a story with something to eat in it," then specifying "a story with something like a barbeque sandwich in it" is
    A) Spiros Antonapoulos.
    B) Love Jones.
    C) George Kelly.
    D) Harry Minowitz.
    E) Spareribs.

40. Suffering from having "both his feet sawed off" is
    A) Bubber.
    B) Highboy.
    C) Leroy.
    D) Louis.
    E) Willie.

41. Emphasizing the importance of historical context as background to the events characterizing the lives of McCullers's townspeople is Brannon's plan to reorganize his files of newspapers, currently organized by international, national, and local news, a plan that follows the death of

A) Spiros Antonapoulos.
B) Alice Brannon.
C) Benedict Copeland.
D) John Singer.
E) Baby Wilson.

42. A "plan to lead more than one thousand Negroes in this country on a march [. . .] to Washington" is revealed to

A) Antonapoulos by Singer.
B) Blount by Copeland.
C) Copeland by Blount.
D) Copeland by Brannon.
E) Singer by Antonapoulos.

Items 43-47 refer to Samuel Taylor Coleridge's

The Rime of the Ancient Mariner
(excerpted)

It is an ancient Mariner,
And he stoppeth one of three.
'By thy long grey beard and glittering eye,
Now wherefore stopp'st thou me?

'The bridegroom's doors are opened wide,
And I am next of kin;
The guests are met, the feast is set:
May'st hear the merry din.'

He holds him with his skinny hand,
'There was a ship,' quoth he.
'Hold off! unhand me, grey-beard loon!'
Eftsoons his hand dropt he.

He holds him with his glittering eye—
The Wedding-Guest stood still,
And listens like a three years' child:
The Mariner hath his will.

The Wedding-Guest sat on a stone:
He cannot choose but hear;
And thus spake on that ancient man,
The bright-eyed Mariner.

"The ship was cheered, the harbour cleared,
Merrily did we drop
Below the kirk, below the hill,
Below the lighthouse top.

The sun came up upon the left,
Out of the sea came he!
And he shone bright, and on the right
Went down into the sea.

Higher and higher every day,
Till over the mast at noon—"
The Wedding-Guest here beat his breast,
For he heard the loud bassoon.

The bride hath paced into the hall,
Red as a rose is she;
Nodding their heads before her goes
The merry minstrelsy.

The Wedding-Guest he beat his breast,
Yet he cannot choose but hear;
And thus spake on that ancient man,
The bright-eyed Mariner.

"And now the storm-blast came, and he
Was tyrannous and strong [. . .]."

43. Some of Samuel Taylor Coleridge's diction choices (*stoppeth*, *eftsoons*, and *spake*, for example) in "The Rime of the Ancient Mariner" reflect a purposeful use of

A) archaism.
B) colloquialism.
C) jargon.
D) neologism.
E) regionalism.

44. The form of Coleridge's "Rime" is the

A) ballad.
B) ballade.
C) envoy.
D) *ottava rima*.
E) *terza rima*.

45. The Wedding-Guest's response (third stanza) to the Mariner's "hold[ing] him with his skinny hand," his calling the Mariner a "grey-beard loon," is an example of metalepsis, specifically a combination of primarily

A) imagery and metonymy.
B) litotes and hyperbole.
C) metaphor and paradox.
D) paradox and zeugma.
E) understatement and hyperbole.

46. The narrative suggests the direction in which the ship is travelling in

A) lines 10-11.
B) lines 21-24.
C) lines 25-28.
D) lines 29-30.
E) lines 41-42.

47. The seventh stanza of "The Rime of the Ancient Mariner," lines 25-28, is characterized by

A) apostrophe.
B) hyperbole.
C) onomatopoeia.
D) personification.
E) synecdoche.

Items 48-50 refer to Samuel Taylor Coleridge's

Frost at Midnight
(excerpted)

The Frost performs its secret ministry,
Unhelped by any wind. The owlet's cry
Came loud–and hark, again! loud as before.
The inmates of my cottage, all at rest,
Have left me to that solitude, which suits
Abstruser musings: save that at my side
My cradled infant slumbers peacefully.
'Tis calm indeed! so calm, that it disturbs
And vexes meditation with its strange
And extreme silentness. Sea, hill, and wood,
This populous village! Sea, and hill, and wood,
With all the numberless goings-on of life,
Inaudible as dreams! the thin blue flame
Lies on my low-burnt fire, and quivers not;
Only that film, which fluttered on the grate,
Still flutters there, the sole unquiet thing.
Methinks, its motion in this hush of nature
Gives it dim sympathies with me who live,
Making it a companionable form,
Whose puny flaps and freaks the idling Spirit
By its own moods interprets, every where
Echo or mirror seeking of itself,
And makes a toy of Thought.

But O! how oft,
How oft, at school, with most believing mind,
Presageful, have I gazed upon the bars,
To watch that fluttering *stranger*! and as oft
With unclosed lids, already had I dreamt
Of my sweet birth-place, and the old church-tower,
Whose bells, the poor man's only music, rang
From morn to evening, all the hot Fair-day,
So sweetly, that they stirred and haunted me
With a wild pleasure, falling on mine ear
Most like articulate sounds of things to come!
So gazed I, till the soothing things, I dreamt,
Lulled me to sleep, and sleep prolonged my dreams!

48. The speaker's musing on both nature and nature's influence on the poet's life and that of his son in Coleridge's "Frost at Midnight" places the poem among Coleridge's

A) art ballads.
B) conversation poems.
C) folk ballads.
D) gothic poems.
E) graveyard poems.

49. The auditory imagery of the speaker's childhood memories is reinforced by line 13's

A) conceit.
B) double entendre.
C) metaphor.
D) simile.
E) zeugma.

50. Serving as an analogue of nature, the "fluttering *stranger*" of line 27 is a/the

A) abstruser musings.
B) film.
C) grate.
D) idling Spirit.
E) member of the populous village.

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism
15 items (2 points each)

Items 51-54 refer to Galway Kinnell's

Blackberry Eating

I love to go out in late September
among the fat, overripe, icy, black blackberries
to eat blackberries for breakfast,
the stalks very prickly, a penalty
they earn for knowing the black art
of blackberry-making; and as I stand among them
lifting the stalks to my mouth, the ripest berries
fall almost unbidden to my tongue,
as words sometimes do, certain peculiar words
like *strengths* or *squinched*,
many-lettered, one-syllabled lumps,
which I squeeze, squinch open, and splurge well
in the silent, startled, icy, black language
of blackberry-eating in late September.

51. Lines 4-6 of Galway Kinnell's sonnet "Blackberry-Eating," which read, "the stalks very prickly, a penalty / they earn for knowing the black art / of blackberry-making," feature a fairly clever play on words known as a(n)

A) barbarism.
B) epiphany.
C) paradox.
D) pun.
E) understatement.

52. The call to the visual and tactile senses is a use of

A) foregrounding.
B) foreshadowing.
C) idiom.
D) imagery.
E) synaesthesia.

53. The turn in Kinnell's sonnet, which occurs in the poem's move from berries to words depends on a(n)

A) diminishing metaphor.
B) hyperbole.
C) metaphor.
D) oxymoron.
E) simile.

54. The melopoeic aspect of Kinnell's poem relies on

A) alliteration.
B) dissonance.
C) end rhyme.
D) imagery.
E) jumping the shark.

Items 55-60 refer to William Shakespeare's

Sonnet 60

Like as the waves make towards the pebbl'd shore,
So do our minutes hasten to their end;
Each changing place with that which goes before,
In sequent* toil all forwards do contend.*
Nativity,* once in the main* of light,
Crawls to maturity, wherewith being crown'd,
Crooked eclipses 'gainst his glory fight,
And Time that gave doth now his gift confound.
Time doth transfix the flourish set on youth
And delves the parallels in beauty's brow,
Feeds on the rarities of nature's truth,
And nothing stands but for his scythe to mow:
And yet to times in hope my verse shall stand,
Praising thy worth, despite his cruel hand.

vocabulary:
line 4: sequent = successive
line 4: contend = struggle
line 5: nativity = newborn life
line 5: main = high seas
line 7: crooked = perverse
line 8: confound = bring to nothing
line 9: transfix = pierce
line 10: parallels = wrinkles
line 13: in hope = in the future

55. Shakespeare's Sonnet 60 is a

A) caudate sonnet.
B) Miltonic sonnet.
C) Petrarchan sonnet.
D) Shakespearean sonnet.
E) Spenserian sonnet.

56. Shakespeare's sonnet begins with a(n)

A) epithet.
B) metaphor.
C) oxymoron.
D) simile.
E) transferred epithet.

57. The "minutes" (line 2), in referring to our lives, constitute an example of the trope called

A) anachronism.
B) hyperbole.
C) litotes.
D) oxymoron.
E) synecdoche.

58. Time, with "his cruel hand" (line 14), exemplifies

A) apostrophe.
B) ethos.
C) pathos.
D) personification.
E) synecdoche.

59. The omission of part of a word to preserve the meter of the poetic line as in *pebbl'd* (line 1), *crown'd* (6), and '*gainst* (7) is called

A) accent.
B) caesura.
C) elision.
D) epanalepsis.
E) metathesis.

60. The imagery found in line 10 is

A) auditory imagery.
B) gustatory imagery.
C) olfactory imagery.
D) tactile imagery.
E) visual imagery.

Items 61-63 refer to Edmund Waller's

Go, Lovely Rose

Go, lovely Rose—
Tell her that wastes her time and me
That now she knows,
When I resemble her to thee,
How sweet and fair she seems to be.

Tell her that's young,
And shuns to have her graces spied,
That hadst thou sprung
In deserts where no men abide,
Thou must have uncommended died.

Small is the worth
Of beauty from the light retired:
Bid her come forth,
Suffer herself to be desired,
And not blush so to be admired.

Then die—that she
The common fate of all things rare
May read in thee:
How small a part of time they share
That are so wondrous sweet and fair.

61. The opening line of Edmund Waller's "Go, Lovely Rose" sets up the poem as a(n)

A) apostrophe.
B) elegy.
C) eulogy.
D) incantation.
E) satire.

62. That which "she / The common fate of all things rare / May read in thee" is

A) beauty.
B) blushing.
C) death.
D) fading beauty.
E) life after death.

63. The theme of Waller's poem can be summed up as

A) *carpe diem*.
B) *in medias res*.
C) *memento mori*.
D) *ubi sunt*.
E) *vade mecum*.

Items 64-65 refer to Sara Teasdale's

"I Have Loved Hours at Sea"

I have loved hours at sea, gray cities,
The fragile secret of a flower,
Music, the making of a poem
That gave me heaven for an hour;

First stars above a snowy hill,
Voices of people kindly and wise,
And the great look of love, long hidden,
Found at last in meeting eyes.

I have loved much and been loved deeply—
Oh, when my spirit's fire burns low,
Leave me the darkness and the stillness;
I shall be tired and glad to go.

64. The continuation of the sense and grammatical construction from the first stanza of Teasdale's poem to the second stanza is called

A) enjambment.
B) exegesis.
C) inversion.
D) parenthesis.
E) truncation.

65. Thematically, Teasdale's "I Have Loved Hours at Sea" addresses a

A) confused stream of consciousness.
B) diminished appreciation of little things.
C) life fulfilled through experience.
D) life lived as a poet.
E) vacation memory.

Required tie-breaking essay prompt on the next page.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay (required)

Note well: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified even if they are not involved in any tie.

Note well: Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The judge(s) should note carefully this criterion when breaking ties: ranking of essays for tie-breaking purposes should be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed.

Three sheets of paper have been provided for this essay; your written response should reflect the *Handbook*'s notion that an essay is a "moderately brief discussion of a restricted topic": something more than just a few sentences.

Read Samuel Taylor Coleridge's "To Nature," and compose an essay that addresses Coleridge's focus on the role of nature in the poet's life.

To Nature

It may indeed be phantasy, when I
  Essay* to draw from all created things — *attempt
  Deep, heartfelt, inward joy that closely clings;
And trace in leaves and flowers that round me lie
Lessons of love and earnest piety.
  So let it be; and if the wide world rings
  In mock of this belief, it brings
Nor fear, nor grief, nor vain perplexity.
So will I build my altar in the fields,
  And the blue sky my fretted* dome shall be, — *ornamentally designed (as in the cloud patterns)
And the sweet fragrance that the wild flower yields
  Shall be the incense I will yield to Thee,
Thee only God! and thou shalt not despise
Even me, the priest of this poor sacrifice.

University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest
District 1 • 2013
KEY

Page numbers are those associated with the *Handbook* 12e, the Mariner 2000 edition of *Heart*, and the Avon 1965 edition of *Earnest*.

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History — **30 items (1 point each)**

1.	C	219	11.	B	227	21.	C	
2.	B	601	12.	E	603	22.	C	269
3.	A	6	13.	B	104	23.	C	27
4.	D	490	14.	A		24.	E	427
5.	D	472	15.	D	387	25.	D	142
6.	B	178	16.	E	261	26.	B	354-55
7.	C	267	17.	E	422	27.	E	413
8.	E	486	18.	B		28.	E	496
9.	E	604	19.	D	607	29.	A	17
10.	C	168	20.	A	200	30.	A	603

Part 2: UIL Reading List — **20 items (2 points each)**

31.	C	28	38.	C	278	45.	A	298
32.	E	47	39.	C	164	46.	C	
33.	A	70	40.	E	255	47.	D	361
34.	B	102	41.	B	133 (122)	48.	B	109
35.	B	79	42.	B	303	49.	D	445
36.	C	92	43.	A	39	50.	B	line15
37.	B	17	44.	A	49			

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism — **15 items (2 points each)**

51.	D	390	56.	D	445	61.	A	37
52.	D	246	57.	E	470	62.	D	
53.	E	445	58.	D	361	63.	A	75
54.	A	13	59.	C	167	64.	A	174
55.	D	442	60.	E		65.	C	

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Samuel Taylor Coleridge's "To Nature"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of Coleridge's poem include

alliteration,
apostrophe,
couplet,
didacticism,
enjambment,
esemplastic power,
imagery (olfactory, visual),
imagination,
inversion,
metaphor,
muse,
near rhyme,
pantheism,
polysyndeton,
run-on,
sonnet,
tone, and
volta.

The student might recognize in the title and in the last three lines that Coleridge's sonnet is an apostrophe, one in which the poet presents a pantheistic view of the universe, one in which the poet offers, as sacrifice (line 14), his poem to inspirational nature. The contestant might spot the didacticism in nature's offering both "Lessons of love" and examples of "earnest Piety" (line 5). Nature in her role as muse is welcomed by the poet who, in the presence of "all created things," will build an "altar in the fields" so that he may thank her.

The young writer might also recognize the conditional structure of the sonnet's argument: "It may indeed be phantasy" and "So let it be" (lines 1 and 6), as well as "and if the wide world rings / In mock of this belief," then the poet will not be troubled (lines 6-8).

The contestant might choose to focus on the "sweet fragrance" of the poet's sacrifice, his drawing from nature (the esemplastic power, the creative aspect of the poet's imagination) the beauty that becomes the imagery of his poetic expression: this very sonnet, his apostrophe addressed to the immediate source of his inspiration, nature.